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SIKKIM

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Naya Drishti Ministries

Solus Christus

Sikkim Theological Journal

We, at Naya Drishti Ministries are delighted to publish this very first issue of the Sikkim Theological Journal. The idea of the journal which would be the first of its kind in this region, was conceived as we felt the need for a platform where biblical scholars, indigenous scholars in particular, would be able to discuss theological topics and also various contemporary issues in our society and offer solutions or suggestions from a biblical perspective.

The motto of our ministry is "God's words are trustworthy and true" which is based on Revelation 21:5. Even two thousand years after John wrote these words, God's words still stand true and can still be trusted. The main objective of our ministry is to present how the truth claims of the Bible are congruent with reality and transcend time, and as Jesus has promised, "and the truth shall make you free".

The views presented by the authors in the journal are expressly their own and may not completely align with the theological position of Naya Drishti Ministries.

Enquiries regarding journal subscriptions, renewals, or any business communication should be addressed to Naya Drishti Ministries, Baptist Church, Sirwani Dochum, East Sikkim, 737134. Enquiries related to submission of articles for the Sikkim Theological Journal may be sent to the Chief Editor at <nayadrishti215@gmail.com>.

Editorial Board:

Chief Editor : **Sanjiv Rai,** M.Th.

Associate Editor : **Sunil Subba,** B.Th., M.Div.

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Editor's Introduction

The theme for the very first issue of the journal is *Solus Christus*, or in other words "Christ alone", one of the five Solas of the Reformation. We are deeply thankful to the authors who have contributed their articles to this issue.

Sanjiv Rai, a scholar from Sikkim who is pursuing a PhD in Theology, emphasizes the need for providing philosophical and logical arguments, in addition to spiritual reasons for the existence of God as he remarks, we are currently living in an era when people have unlimited access to information on any topic under the sun and they want more compelling and verifiable reasons for them to subscribe to a belief and faith in God. However, he explains, we do not need to abandon reason when we embrace our faith by suggesting that the Five Ways propounded by Thomas Aquinas can be a helpful tool in understanding how observing the world and using our reasoning power actually points us towards the existence of God. While reason helps us recognize the existence of God, faith in Christ is what enables us to find and live out our purpose.

Kushal Rai, Principal, Darjeeling Hills Bible School, who is also an ordained minister with the Eastern Himalayan Church Council, UCNI addresses a frequently asked question, which is also something to reflect on as we will soon be celebrating Christmas, about why it was necessary for Christ to come into this world—why he had to take on human form for the propitiation of our sins. He explains that we can find the answer to this mystery which is fundamental to our faith, by understanding God's attributes of holiness and justice and how that understanding should lead us also to pursue holiness and righteousness.

Sujan Pradhan, an Old Testament scholar from Nepal, gives us contrasting pictures of liberation offered by God and Satan. He takes us back to the garden of Eden where God had created human beings in his own image and granted them freedom and dominion over all the earth. However, Satan enters the scene and deceives them with an offer that would lead to destruction in the form of spiritual separation from God and eventually, physical death. Thus, the world has been infected with sin and the consequences of sin ever since. In the present context, he points out the deception that has infiltrated churches in Nepal in the form of deceptive teachings and social discrimination based on caste or class that still exist in some

churches. He suggests that Christ-centred teachings can help them attain liberation from societal shackles and dangers of false teachings.

Kapsuanmung, a scholar from Manipur, has written on a topic that every single one of our readers would be able to relate to—the problem of suffering. As he points out, often as one encounters a horrific tragedy, they are left wondering if God really does exist and if he does and is indeed good, why he would allow pain and suffering also to exist. He gives reasons based on the Bible for why God allows us to undergo suffering sometimes highlighting that Christ was the Greatest Sufferer and we as followers of Christ, are to even anticipate suffering as an integral part of our faith.

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Faith and Reason in the Philosophy of Thomas Aquinas: Its Contemporary Relevance for Defending Christ in a Rational World

Sanjiv Rai[1*]

Abstract: Thomas Aquinas during the thirteenth century, developed the Five Ways arguments as a way to show that faith and reason can be reconciled. This was a groundbreaking idea for that period, as faith and reason were considered to be mutually exclusive. Whereas during the time of Aquinas, people prioritised faith over reason, in the present context, the converse is true. Aquinas's propositions can be useful in both these scenarios in helping both the simple believer think and the rational thinker believe, as the gift of understanding can be used to gain a deeper understanding of the truth which will ultimately lead to faith in Christ and as he has proclaimed, he is the Truth.

INTRODUCTION

This study aims to provide an overview of Thomas Aquinas's understanding of the relationship between reason and faith. The purpose of this paper is to explore the philosophical contributions of Aquinas and to examine their contemporary relevance in defending Christianity in a rational world. The researcher has delved into the key aspects of Aquinas's thought, including his philosophy of faith and reason, his understanding of their interrelationship, and the Post-Modern scholars' discourse on these concepts. The paper concludes by uncovering how Aquinas's philosophy can serve as a guiding light in addressing the perceived dichotomy between faith and reason and in defending faith in Christ in a world increasingly governed by rationality.

A BRIEF OVERVIEW OF THOMAS AQUINAS

St. Thomas Aquinas was born in 1225 at the castle of Roccasecca in Italy, as the youngest son of Count Landulf of Aquino, a noble family.[2] According to Edward J. Gratsch, "His father belonged to the Lombard nobility; his paternal grandmother, Francesca di Suabia, was a sister of Frederick Barbarossa, emperor of the Holy Roman Empire; and his mother was descended from Norman nobility."[3] Thomas was the eighth of nine children of Landulf of Aquino, born to his wife, Theodora.[4] Thomas Aquinas enrolled at the University of Naples, the oldest public, secular, state-funded university in the world. It was here that he was first

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[1] [*]Sanjiv Rai, M.Th. (Christian Theology) is a scholar from Sikkim, India currently pursuing Ph. D. in Theology.

[2] Alister E. McGrath, *Historical Theology: An Introduction to the History of Christian Thought,* 2nd ed. (Hoboken, New Jersey: Wiley-Blackwell, 2021), 91.

[3] Edward J. Gratsch, *Aquinas' Summa: An Introduction and Interpretation* (Bangalore: Theological publications in India, 1990), xi.

[4] Frederick Christian and Bauers Chmidt, *Holy Teaching: Introducing the Summa Theologiae of St. Thomas Aquinas* (Grand Rapids, Michigan: Brazos Press, 2005), 13.

introduced to the works of Aristotle, an encounter that would greatly shape his intellectual journey.[5] Aquinas later authored the renowned *Summa Theologiae*, a comprehensive work in which he recorded his philosophical and theological insights systematically. This research relies on *Summa Theologiae* as a primary source for its analysis. Frederick opines, "In February 1274, despite his physical frailty, he was summoned to attend the Council of Lyon, which sought to reunite the Eastern and Western churches. However, during his journey, a sudden accident—a blow to the head from a low-hanging tree branch—halted his progress." Tragically, on March 7, 1274, Thomas Aquinas passed away, leaving behind a legacy of profound theological contributions. His life and work continue to be of relevance and significance, offering invaluable insights into the relationship between faith and reason[6], a topic which we will now explore further.

AQUINAS'S PHILOSOPHY OF FAITH AND REASON

During Thomas Aquinas's time, the works of Aristotle, particularly those on science and metaphysics, were banned at many universities, most notably at the University of Paris.[7] The works of Aristotle were banned primarily because of the strong prevailing emphasis on faith, with authorities resisting any attempt to synthesize faith and reason. As Bernard notes, "No good Christian in Thomas's time doubted the pope's supremacy over the Church, and Thomas, along with his fellow Dominicans, were among the papacy's most loyal supporters."[8]

Bernard suggests that people of that era were not inclined towards rational thinking. Similarly, Ramm opines that during the medieval period, people read Scripture through the lens of spirituality, which posed a significant problem as they neglected to use reason or natural revelation in their interpretation. Thomas Aquinas addressed this issue by stating, "The relationship between faith and reason explains how he can maintain a clear distinction between them while rejecting any abrupt separation. They do not exclude one another; on the contrary, while reason can function independently of faith, faith cannot function without reason. Science remains science when illuminated by revelation, just as sensation and emotion are not diminished but enhanced when guided by intelligence and friendship."[9] Thomas Aquinas clearly explained how faith and reason function in harmony. He argued that

[5] Gerard M. Verschuuren, *Aquinas and Modern Science: A New Synthesis of Faith and Reason* (USA: Angelico Press, 2016), Z. Library e-book, 12.

[6] Gratsch, *Aquinas' Summa*, xi.

[7] Christian and Chmidt, *Holy Teaching*, 14.

[8] Bernard McGinn, *Thomas Aquinas's Summa Theologia* (United States of America: Princeton University Press, 2014), 9.

[9] St Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* Vol 1, trans. Thomas Gilby (United States of America: New York, Cambridge University Press, 2006), Z. Library e-book, 101.

human emotion and intellect always work in tandem, complementing rather than opposing one another.

During Thomas Aquinas's time, there was a considerable gap between the scientific advancements and the tenets of faith, with the rapid development of science posing what was perceived as a threat to the Christian religion. In this context, Aquinas's philosophical system emerged as a crucial bridge between reason and faith. To demonstrate the compatibility of faith with reason, Aquinas formulated his renowned "Five Ways" arguments to prove the existence of God. Each of these arguments follows a rational structure:

1. **The Argument from Motion**: Observing that everything in motion is set in motion by something else, Aquinas concluded that there must be an Unmoved Mover, which is God.
2. **The Argument from Causality**: Noting that every effect has a cause, he posited the necessity of a First Cause, which itself is uncaused—this First Cause is God.
3. **The Argument from Contingency**: Recognizing that all beings are contingent (i.e. they could either exist or not exist), Aquinas argued for the existence of a necessary being that must exist and cannot not exist—God.
4. **The Argument from Perfection**: Aquinas observed varying degrees of qualities like goodness, truth, and nobility in the world and concluded that there must be a perfect being that is the source of all perfection, which he identified as God.
5. **The Argument from Design**: Finally, seeing the order and purpose in the natural world, Aquinas asserted that this order must be the result of an intelligent designer—God.[10]

As Peter Kreeft notes, "These five arguments begin with the empirical observation of five features in the cosmos: motion, causality, contingency, imperfection, and order… The arguments from cosmic design have even convinced highly sophisticated scientists like Einstein and philosophers like the former atheist Antony Flew."[11] Aquinas's arguments remain influential in bridging the gap between faith and reason, offering a rational foundation for belief in God.

THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN FAITH AND REASON

[10] Verschuuren, *Aquinas and Modern Science*, 20.
[11] Verschuuren, *Aquinas and Modern Science*, 20.

According to Paul J. Glenn, an interpreter of *Summa Theologiae*, "In the *Summa Theologiae*, Second Part, Thomas states that man requires a sound grasp of the truth of faith, which is provided through the gift of understanding. Furthermore, man must ensure that he makes correct judgments, illuminated by faith, in all matters and situations of life; this is facilitated by the gift of knowledge."[12] Here, Thomas emphasizes the significance of both faith and reason in Christian life. He asserts that human reason does not diminish the value of faith; rather, it enhances and amplifies its worth.[13]

The researcher of this paper offers an illustrative example to elucidate the depth of this concept: Imagine you are driving on a road and you notice a rising cloud of smoke in the distance. Even without directly seeing the fire, you instinctively conclude that a fire must exist. While the fire itself remains unseen, the visible smoke serves as evidence of its presence. In a similar vein, faith can be likened to the fire—intangible and invisible—while reason is akin to the smoke, providing tangible signs that affirm and clear the path for faith. Just as smoke reveals the existence of fire, reason helps to remove obstacles to faith, making the unseen reality of faith more accessible and comprehensible. Pope St. John Paul II said, "Faith and reason are like two wings on which the human spirit rises in contemplation of truth." Jesus also said, "You shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free (John 8:32)."

POST-MODERN PERSPECTIVE ON FAITH AND REASON

Having explored Aquinas's philosophy of faith and reason and examined their interrelationship, we now turn to the discourse of post-modern scholars on these concepts. This shift in perspective has significantly influenced contemporary interpretations and discussions, shaping how today's readers engage with the philosophy of faith and reason.

John W. Danford observed that during the Post-Modern era, reason was elevated above faith. This shift led to a demand for empirical evidence to validate all claims. For example, if science (reason) cannot demonstrate that water can be transformed into wine, then the account is often dismissed as a myth or a mere story.[14]

Reimarus and other proponents of the historical quest critically challenged traditional Christianity under the influence of rationalism. In this context, they introduced the concept of

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[12] Paul J. Gleen, *A Tour of the Summa of St. Thomas Aquinas* (Bangalore: Theological Publications in India, 2001), 193.

[13] Gleen, *A Tour of the Summa,*193.

[14] John W. Danfor, *David Hume and the Problem of Reason* (London: Yale University Press, 1990), Z. Library e-book, 13-15.

'rational orthodoxy,'[15] asserting that reason should be the primary tool for studying the Bible. Consequently, scholars began to approach the Bible as they would any other literary text, rather than as the divine revelation of God. They sought to explain biblical narratives solely through natural laws, rejecting the supernatural elements, such as miracles, found in the text. Ultimately, they concluded that the Bible should be regarded as a work of ethical and moral instruction, devoid of any unique theological teachings.[16]

Reimarus and his disciples made a complete distinction between faith and reason, with their reliance on reason alone raising significant questions about the divine nature of Christ and the authority of Scripture. In response, another group of scholars developed the theology of the "Christ of Faith." We will now examine their contributions to understand how they addressed these challenges.

A group of scholars, led by Rudolf Bultmann and Ernst Käsemann, emerged to address the challenges posed by Reimarus and his followers. Bultmann argued that the historical Jesus's personality cannot be definitively uncovered and is ultimately irrelevant to theology. He contended that the gospel narratives are expressions of faith, emphasizing that the "Christ of faith" holds greater significance for Christianity than the historical Jesus or the principles of natural law.[17]

Bultmann emphasized that Christians should interpret the Gospels through the lens of faith, asserting that the Christ who dwells within believers is more significant than the historical Jesus. For instance, Bultmann argued that if one prays for the sick in the name of Christ, healing will come through the indwelling Christ, rather than through the historical Jesus of Nazareth. This suggests that, according to Bultmann, the Christ who dwells within the believer is more significant than the historical Jesus. This distinction highlights his emphasis on the Christ of faith over the historical Jesus. He and his colleagues sought to elevate faith above human reason, creating a distinction between the "Jesus of history" and the "Christ of faith." Their focus was on the living presence of Jesus within believers, rather than the historical facts of his life.

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[15] Gerald Bray, *Biblical Interpretation: Past and Present* (Illinois: InterVarsity Press, 1996), 228.

[16] Joel Joseph, *Methodological Issues in Interpreting the Old Testament passages: Socio-anthropological, Hybridity & Subaltern Perspectives* (Delhi: Christian World Imprints, 2020), 28.

[17] Stephen E. Paynter, "The Quests of the Historical Jesus: A Review from an Evangelical Perspective," *Banner of Research Gate* (6 November 2015), https://www.researchgate.net/publiciation/302904950-The-Quests-for-the-Historical-Jesus-A-Review-from-an-Evangelical-Perspective.

When the "Christ of faith" was placed above reason, a significant issue arose: Christian faith no longer relied on historical evidence. This approach created a wide chasm between the historical Jesus and the Christ of faith. Similarly, the earlier group, in prioritizing reason over faith, inadvertently led people to question the very existence of Christ.

In the contemporary context, there is a prevailing trend of prioritizing reason over faith, with many perceiving the Bible merely as a historical document and viewing Christ solely as a moral teacher. This shift contrasts sharply with the era of Thomas Aquinas, when faith was often accepted uncritically, based on ecclesiastical authority rather than reasoned understanding. Aquinas, however, endeavored to achieve a balance between faith and reason, advocating that both are essential for a holistic understanding of divine truth. In light of this, it may be helpful for today's readers to draw on Aquinas's philosophy to develop a balanced approach that harmonizes faith and reason. Without such a balance, advancing in the Christian journey becomes challenging, as it necessitates integrating both faith and reason to achieve a fuller understanding of spiritual and rational truths.

DEFENDING CHRIST IN A RATIONAL WORLD

In this section, the researcher presents several recommendations for defending Christ in a reason-centric world. While readers may devise their own approaches to this challenge, the suggestions provided aim to offer valuable guidance for navigating the rise of reason and effectively defending the Christian faith.

In the 21st century, reason has increasingly challenged the core beliefs of Christianity, prompting believers to rethink how they defend their faith in a rational world. Rationalists argue that since these occurrences cannot be scientifically verified, key events like the resurrection of Christ, the virgin birth, and biblical miracles are often dismissed as myths or symbolic narratives rather than historical truths. Furthermore, reason has called into question the authority of Scripture. Through historical and literary criticism, scholars have treated the Bible as a purely human document, casting doubt on its divine inspiration and challenging the historical accuracy of biblical accounts. Finally, the rise of rationalism and secularism has promoted a worldview in which religious faith is viewed as unnecessary or irrational as secularism is driven by a belief in reason as the sole path to knowledge.

To defend Christ in this rational world, we must embrace a Christ-centered approach that harmonizes faith and reason, recognizing that both are essential to a fuller understanding of God's truth. Thomas Aquinas's philosophy provides a framework for this by teaching that reason, when grounded in Christ, becomes a tool to deepen our faith. Reason can lead us to recognize the existence of God, the moral law, and the order of creation, but it is through Christ that we gain access to divine revelation and the fullness of God's plan for humanity.

As the Incarnation of God, Christ represents the ultimate union of divine wisdom and human understanding. Therefore, in the quest for truth, reason must serve the revelation of Christ, who provides the answers to the deepest questions about our existence, purpose, and salvation—questions that reason alone cannot fully address. Practically, this means that defending Christ in a rational world requires engaging in both theological and philosophical reflections.

In this Christ-centered balance, we affirm that reason is a gift from God to help us understand his creation better, while faith in Christ is what brings us into communion with God's ultimate truth. By integrating both, we can offer a compelling defense of Christ that resonates with both the rational mind and the spiritual heart, standing firm in the belief that Christ is the way, the truth, and the life.

CONCLUSION

Thomas Aquinas' integration of faith and reason continues to offer a compelling framework for understanding Christian theology, especially in the context of 21st-century challenges. In an era where digital technologies and the vast availability of information shape perceptions, individuals have become increasingly critical and inquisitive about matters of faith. Relying solely on personal experiences is no longer sufficient; people now seek rational, coherent explanations for their beliefs. In this light, Aquinas' philosophy remains profoundly relevant, providing a robust intellectual foundation for addressing modern inquiries into the Christian faith.

This paper has offered a short introduction to Aquinas's thought, alongside an exploration of contemporary scholarly discussions on the interrelationship between faith and reason. Additionally, it has emphasized the practical implications of this philosophical approach, particularly in encouraging readers to engage critically and confidently in the

defense of Christian beliefs in a reason-centered world. While this work provides a foundational understanding of Aquinas's philosophy, it also aims to stimulate further scholarly inquiry, inviting more comprehensive studies into the enduring relevance of his thought in contemporary theological discourse.

Glossary

Philosophy. Philosophy is the study of ideas about life, knowledge, truth, and existence, seeking to understand how we think and why things are the way they are. In simple terms, it is about thinking deeply and asking big questions about the world and our place in it.

Theology. Theology is the study of God, religious beliefs, and the nature of faith. It explores questions about the divine, the meaning of life, and the relationship between humans and God.

Reason. Reason, in simple terms, refers to the ability to think, understand, and form judgment logically. It is a mental process of making sense of things and drawing conclusions based on evidence or facts.

Faith. A confident belief or trust in religious doctrines or the existence of God, often without direct proof.

Christ of Faith. According to Bultmann, Christ of faith refers to the understanding of Jesus Christ based on faith and the transformative experience of the believer, rather than historical facts.

Historical Jesus. The historical Jesus refers to the actual, historical Jesus of Nazareth.

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Why the God Man?[18]

Kushal Rai[19*]

Abstract: The author of the Gospel according to John, described as the beloved disciple in the epilogue, begins by stating the divinity of Jesus, the Eternal Word, one in essence with God (the Father). Then in the fourteenth verse of the same chapter, he writes, "And the Word became flesh…" which in simple words means that Jesus, the Eternal God took on human flesh and became a true man. In doing so, Jesus became true God and true man: one person with two natures—divine and human. Traditionally, Christmas is celebrated as the day of the incarnation of Christ (Jesus, the Eternal God taking on himself human nature, in addition to his eternal divine nature). So, the question that seeks an answer is, why did Jesus (God) become a man, or in simpler terms, why Christmas? This paper will try to succinctly answer the theological meaning and significance as well as practical implications of this grand unique truth.

INTRODUCTION

In the first two centuries (AD), there was controversy concerning the humanity of Christ, especially due to the influence of the Greek philosophy of Gnosticism[20]. Such unbiblical understanding is prevalent and influential even today. Thus, it is imperative for us to understand the meaning, the need, and the significance of why the divine became human.

JESUS THE INCARNATE SON

The Bible presents to us that Jesus Christ is the eternally begotten Son of God, who is in one essence with the Father (Ps. 2; John 1; Col. 1,2), yet this Eternal Son became the Incarnate Son (John 1:14; Phil. 2:6). The incarnation of the Eternal Son is unique as well as a fundamental basis of the Christian faith. Speaking of the nuance of this uniqueness, John Murray writes, "It is on the premises of his eternal identity as God, his eternal subsistence as the only begotten Son, his creative activity at the beginning, and his continued activity in sustaining all created reality, that we can conceive the fact and meaning of the incarnation."[21] Furthermore, he states that the Son of God became what he eternally was not.[22] The Eternal Son taking on human flesh (nature) is theologically understood as the beginning of the

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18 The title of the article is the title of a book written by a man named Anselm of Canterbury (1094-1098) titled *Cur Deus Homo* (Latin).

19 * Kushal Rai, B.Com., M.Div., M. Th. is Principal, Darjeeling Hills Bible College and is also an ordained minister with the Eastern Himalayan Church Council, UCNI.

20 A dualistic Greek philosophy of spirit and matter, wherein spirit is said to be pure and matter sinful. Thus, according to this philosophy, it is impossible for Christ to take on human form (sinful).

21 John Murray, *Collected Writings of John Murray 2: Selected Lectures in Systematic Theology* (Carlisle, PENN: The Banner of Truth Trust, 1977), 132.

22 Murray, *Collected Writings*, 132.

humiliation of Christ.[23] Flesh connotes the idea of human weakness, futility, and inability (John 1:13, 3:6, 6:63).[24] John Calvin commenting on the incarnation speaks of the descent from the height of glory to a mean and despicable condition, frail and perishable.[25] Thus, Murray beautifully sums up the humiliation of Christ in his incarnation, stating that "the infinite became finite, the eternal and supratemporal entered time and became subject to its conditions, the immutable became mutable, the invisible became visible, the Creator became the created, the sustainer of all became dependent, the Almighty infirm."[26]

However, when we speak of the incarnation of Christ, it is essential to understand that Christ did not cease to be divine. The incarnation as Beeke and Smalley state, "was not an act of subtraction in which the Son cast off his deity, but one of addition in which he embraced our humanity."[27] By taking to himself flesh, the Eternal Son became human in all our weaknesses without ceasing to be God.[28] Thus, God-man: true God and true man. Again, we also need to understand that the humanity of the Son of God did not cease after his resurrection and ascension. Even after his resurrection, he remained a man with natural body (Lk. 24:39) and now after his ascension, with his session at the right hand of the Father, sympathetically interceding on our behalf, he does so in his humanity. Furthermore, it is as the Son of Man, he will return with great glory to judge and to rule (Mark 13:26). And finally, it is as the Lamb, he will dwell with his bride in the new creation (Rev. 21:22-23, 22:1,3).[29] John Owen stated this beautiful truth as "the glory of the Christian religion—the basis and foundation that bears the whole superstructure—the root whereon it grows. This is its life and treasure."[30] But what was the necessity[31] for such a mysterious, unique yet voluntary[32] act of the Eternal Son?

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23 Humiliation of Christ is theologically understood as one of the two states of Christ, the other being the Glorification of Christ. The state refers to the condition of Christ according to the law (reference to class notes of Dr. Mohan Chacko, PTS, Dehradun).

24 Joel R. Beeke & Paul M. Smalley, *Reformed Systematic Theology: Vol. 2 Man and Christ* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2020), 784-85.

25 Beeke and Smalley, *Reformed Systematic Theology 2*, 785.

26 Murray, *Collected Writings*, 132.

27 Murray, *Collected Writings*, 789.

28 Murray, *Collected Writings*, 789.

29 Murray, *Collected Writings*, 797.

30 Murray, *Collected Writings*, 839.

31 Calvin in his commentary on Rom. 3:21-26, regarding the necessity of the incarnation (adding to his divine nature) said, "since neither as God alone could he feel death, nor as man alone could he overcome it, he coupled human nature with divine."

32 The Son was not compelled by the Father. Christ, the Eternal Son fully knew the Father's demand—the life he had to live and the death he had to die and yet obeyed fully and willingly, thus, a voluntary act.

HUMAN SIN AND INABILITY & HOLINESS AND JUSTICE OF GOD: THE UNBRIDGEABLE GAP

The answer to this question begins, first, with our understanding of what human sin is. Sin is a conscious, voluntary, rebellious, and selfish act of man which is in direct contradiction to the sovereign, holy, and righteous God. Sin insults and offends God and it makes man his enemy and a slave to sin. "Sin is horrible because it is an affront to God"[33], states Joel Beeke. In other words, sin is theocentric and a violation of the Creator-creature relationship.[34]

Sin is not just a principle or an idea but a reality which happened in real time and in history.[35] Sin first occurred in the spiritual world (vaguely described in the Bible), entered into this material world through the disobedience (rebellion) of Adam, the covenant head of the entire mankind, as he was tempted by Satan in the form of a serpent (Gen. 3). This rebellious, sinful, and covenant-breaking act of Adam, rather than merely being an act of an individual, was an act of a representative head of the entire human race. As a result, Adam and in him, all his posterity became sinners, covenant-breakers, and enemies of God. This is the state in which all the posterity of Adam is born with, which is referred to as the 'original sin' (Ps. 51:5). This sin, which is the disposition of a natural man, results in actual sin. Such is the corruption and pollution of our sin that no good (divinely speaking) or merit abides in us; we are totally depraved. Thus, the biblical idea of total depravity implies that the entire disposition of man (every part of man), the very core of man is affected and influenced by sin.

Depravity addresses the core issue of the human heart. The heart which is the core of man is depraved and polluted by sin (Matt. 15:17-20) such that the natural man has no ability to do anything that is pleasing to God. Speaking of the natural state of man, Calvin writes that the human heart is "a perpetual factory of idols".[36] Human depravity implies that we are spiritually impotent[37], unable to change our condition of sin. It means that we are totally unable to save ourselves. Furthermore, total depravity implies that as sinners, we are slaves to sin and because of our sinful disposition, we are enemies of God and hate all that is right. Thus, we are not only unable but also unwilling to be restored into fellowship with God. Yet

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33 Joel R. Beeke, *Living for God's Glory: An Introduction to Calvinism* (Orlando, FL: Reformation Trust Publishing, 2008), 42.

34 John MacArthur and Richard Mayhue, eds., *Biblical Doctrine: A Systematic Summary of Bible Truth* (Wheaton, ILL: Crossway, 2017), 453.

35 Beeke and Smalley, *Reformed Systematic Theology 2*, 346.

36 John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion,* I:XI.VL.

37 Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, 55.

the holiness and righteousness of God demands that justice be served, every sinner be punished with the just judgment of eternal death and hell.

Therefore, secondly, we answer the question by understanding the holiness and justice of God. Holiness of God, in the Bible, is primarily understood ontologically. It means that God in his essential being (nature) is fully distinct from the entire creation. There is nothing in creation that can be compared with God. He is incomparable, distinct, separate, and infinitely perfect. However, the Bible also speaks of the holiness of God morally. The moral perfection of God not only distances God from all that is in creatures but also speaks of his holy wrath and hatred towards all that is sinful.

Justice of God relates to the righteousness of God. Beeke states, "righteousness and justice are essential attributes of God and central to Christ's work".[38] At the outset, we need to understand what we mean by the righteousness of God. Berkhof defines it as "that perfection of God by which he maintains himself over against every violation of his holiness and shows in every respect that he is the holy one."[39] Thus, both the attributes of God, holiness and righteousness, are closely related to the justice of God. Furthermore, God who is holy and righteous is also absolutely sovereign which reveals that his justice is perfect. Justice is the "very nature of God, the foundation of his throne, that is, the undergirding principle of his reign."[40] God, whose justice is not arbitrary, demands that all unrighteousness must be paid with equity.

JESUS THE ATONING SACRIFICE AND THE PENAL SUBSTITUTE: THE GAP BRIDGED

Thus, the answer to the aforementioned question about why the Eternal Son became the Incarnate Son is, to satisfy the just demand of a righteous God on account of sinful humans. Sin fractured the original state of creation and made man an enemy of the holy and righteous God and exposed him to his divine wrath. Sin demands payment and sacrifice without which there can be no peace between the two parties. But the sinfulness of man was such that man, neither by self-sacrifice nor by any other substitute (animal sacrifice), could atone for his sins. Therefore, God himself, according to his divine provision, sent his Son, the eternally divine, as a true human to be a perfect sacrifice and atone for our sins. Wesley stated, "Nothing in the Christian system is of greater consequence than the doctrine of atonement."[41]

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[38] Beeke and Smalley, *Reformed Systematic Theology 2*, 810.

[39] Louis Berkhof, *Manual of Christian Doctrine* (Grand Rapids, MI: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co., 1993), 68.

[40] Beeke and Smalley, *Reformed Systematic Theology 2*, 812.

[41] Graham A. Cole, *God the Peacemaker: How Atonement brings Shalom, NSBT 25* (Downers Grove, IL: 2009), 122.

Jesus's atoning work was a penal substitution. It means that Jesus Christ took upon himself the full punishment that sinners, the elect, deserved for their sins in their place.[42] His death as an atoning sacrifice was a substitutionary act, wherein he is a representative of his people. It is in their place that he bore the condemnation.[43] This idea of penal substitution can be traced to the work of Athanasius, as early as the fourth century, who wrote, 'Thus, taking a body, like our own, because all our bodies were liable to the corruption of death, he surrendered his body to death instead of all, and offered it to the Father.'[44] Following the tradition of Athanasius and the like, Calvin stressed the substitutionary nature of Christ's death when he wrote, 'to take away our condemnation, it was not enough for him to suffer any kind of death: to make satisfaction for our redemption, a form of death had to be chosen in which he might free us both by transferring our condemnation to himself and by taking our guilt (Lat. *piaculum*) upon himself . . . This is our acquittal: the guilt that held us liable for punishment has been transferred to the head of the Son of God (Is. 53:12).'[45] Calvin, therefore argues that the penal substitution of Christ, is the price and penalty paid to satisfy God's righteous judgment and wrath. Thus, Graham Cole concluded, "No incarnation, no atonement. No atonement, no gospel."[46]

PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

The Eternal Son who became the Incarnate Son, as our atoning substitute, has accomplished for us, dead sinners, all that was imperative yet impossible for us to achieve. His complete, finished work demands worship and praise for so great a salvation. Furthermore, it has profound implications in our lives:

1. **Seek, receive, and savour Christ as our Saviour:** Christ, the Incarnate, has propitiated and expiated the just demands of a holy and righteous God for sinners' sake and comes seeking after lost sinners.[47] Even as he comes seeking, we need to seek him too, especially in his word, as Thomas Watson said, "So look unto him, as to believe in him, so that Christ may not only be united to our nature, but also to our

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42 https://www.thegospelcoalition.org/essay/substitutionary-atonement

43 Donald MacLeod, *Christ Crucified: Understanding the Atonement* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2014), 92.

44 Athanasius, *The Incarnation of the Word of God*, tr. A Religious of C.S.M.V. (London: Geoffrey Bles, 1944), 84.

45 John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion,* II:XVI.

46 Cole, *God the Peacemaker*, 137.

47 Beeke and Smalley, *Reformed Systematic Theology 2*, 859.

person."[48] Furthermore, it is necessary that we receive and savour him as our one and only perfect saviour.[49]

2. **Wonder upon this mysterious Saviour and relate to him as our elder brother[50]:** Paul in 1 Tim. 3:16 refers to the incarnation of the Eternal Son as the mystery of godliness. The incarnation is the greatest miracle of God for our salvation. Regarding this, Rutherford wrote, "When I look to my guiltiness, I see that my salvation is one of our Saviour's greatest miracles, either in heaven or earth."[51] Yet we are called not only to marvel and wonder upon this great mystery but also to draw near to him and relate to him as our elder brother. The author of the book of Hebrews in chapter 2, verse 14 states that the Incarnate God took on flesh and blood for our sake, his brothers, in order to deliver them from the power of sin and death. Thus, Wilhelmus à Brakel wrote, "Since he has become our brother, we may and must have fellowship with him as such…This yields boldness and familiarities to bring all our needs before him…"[52]
3. **Praise God for his gift of the Son:** It was the eternal plan of the Father, for the salvation of his own, to send his only Eternal Son to become the Incarnate Son. Paul in 2 Cor. 5:21 wrote that the Son who knew no sin became cursed for our salvation. John Boys wrote that this work of redemption is "a work of greater might and mercy than all the rest: for in the creation he made man like himself; but in the redemption he made himself like man."[53]
4. **Imitate Christ's pattern as a model of holiness and humility:** To be conformed into the image of his Son is one of the primary purposes of God for us and without imitating Christ, our elder brother and pattern, it is impossible. Thomas Goodwin states that just as Christ took on our human nature in order to be our perfect mediator, we too must endeavour to fit ourselves to have communion and fellowship with him by pursuing holiness by his grace.[54] That we are his is evident through our serious, conscious pursuit of holy living.

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48 Thomas Watson, *Body of Divinity* (Edinburgh, UK: The Banner of Truth Trust, 1965), 165.

49 Beeke and Smalley, *Reformed Systematic Theology 2*, 859.

50 Beeke and Smalley, *Reformed Systematic Theology 2*, 861.

51 Beeke and Smalley, *Reformed Systematic Theology 2*, 860; Samuel Rutherford, *Letters of Samuel Rutherford,* ed. Andrew Bonar (Edinburgh, UK: The Banner of Truth Trust, 1984), 320.

52 Beeke and Smalley, *Reformed Systematic Theology 2*, 860; Wilhelmus à Brakel, *The Christian's Reasonable Service* Vol 2, ed. Joel R. Beeke, trans. Bartel Elshout, (Grand Rapids, MI: Reformation Heritage Books, 1992-1995), 516.

53 Beeke and Smalley, *Reformed Systematic Theology 2*, 860.

54 Beeke and Smalley, *Reformed Systematic Theology 2*, 861.

We are to imitate Christ not only with regard to our pursuit of holiness, but also with regard to our humility. Christ, who in essence, being divine became a lowly servant and obedient to the will of the Father to the point of death on the cross demands that we too must embrace such humility. Perkins said, "He was content to lie in a manger, that we might rest in heaven. This serves to teach us to be content to bear any mean [lowly] condition that the Lord shall send upon us; for this is the very estate of the Son of God himself."[55]

5. **Defend the truth of Christ and his works:** The truth of Christ and his redemptive act has not only been misunderstood but attacked vehemently. This has always been the case since the very beginning. The incarnation of the Eternal Son and his substitutionary atoning work on our behalf is utterly imperative and fundamental for our reconciliation, redemption, and restoration. This core fundamental belief must be defended at all costs.
6. **Have assurance and certainty in the Saviour for future glory:** The Eternal Son became the Incarnate Son to be our mediator, our Passover Lamb to die in our stead for our sins. His loud scream on the cross 'It is finished' proves that his earthly ministry as our High Priest and sacrifice is complete. His resurrection from the death is a vindication of the Father that all that he willed has been fulfilled by the Son on our behalf. Furthermore, his resurrection which is the first fruit (1 Cor. 15:20) is an assurance and a certificate of our future resurrection. All that the Father required of him as our substitute has been fulfilled and our future glory is assured eternally.

CONCLUSION

"Why the God Man?" is the greatest mystery and miracle of the eternal plan of God according to his perfect wisdom. It was necessary, for the Father himself deemed it a necessity for the fulfilment of his eternal salvific purpose of saving his own, the elect, who were dead in sins and trespasses. The incarnation of the Eternal Son exemplified his unconditional love for his people in order that he alone may receive glory and praise forever and ever.

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[55] Beeke and Smalley, *Reformed Systematic Theology 2,* 862.

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Dual Liberation in Genesis 3 and its Relevance to the Contemporary Christian Community in Nepal

Sujan Pradhan[56*]

Abstract: This article examines the concept of dual liberation in Genesis 3, contrasting the serpent's deceptive promise of autonomy, which leads to physical and spiritual death, with God's redemptive actions that point to ultimate freedom in Christ. It applies this theological insight to the Nepali Christian community, addressing challenges such as caste discrimination, social stratification, and deceptive teachings that hinder unity and mission. Emphasizing the Gospel's message of equality, service, and reconciliation, the study calls for the church to prioritize scriptural truth and resist societal pressures. By doing so, the Nepali church can dismantle barriers, foster inclusivity, and reflect Christ's vision of unity, offering a transformative path for both spiritual and social growth.

INTRODUCTION

This research paper explores the dual concept of liberation in Genesis 3, highlighting the contrasting roles of God and Satan and their implications for ultimate liberation through Christ. Initially, Genesis presents a liberation narrative, depicting humanity's dominion (Gen. 1:28-31). However, the serpent's temptation leads to alienation from God (Gen. 3:22-24). This study differentiates between God's "transformative liberation" which promotes harmony within divine boundaries and the serpent's "destructive liberation" resulting in physical and spiritual death. This theme continues in the New Testament, where Jesus offers liberation from sin (John 1:29, 8:36).

The paper emphasises the relevance of this framework to contemporary issues, particularly concerning the heretical teachings and persistent class and caste systems in the Nepali Christian community in Sikkim and beyond. It raises critical questions about the community's adherence to these teachings and the Church's perpetuation of social stratification, uncovering the complexities of faith intersecting with social structures.

GENESIS CREATION ACCOUNT

Genesis 1 and 2 offer foundational insights into creation, emphasising God's act of creating *ex nihilo* and establishing order. Genesis 1 details creation over six days, culminating in human beings made in God's image and divine rest on the seventh day (Gen. 1:26-27). Laurence A. Turner notes the repeated declarations of creation being "good," culminating in "very good" (Gen. 1:31), underscoring its intrinsic value and order. However, Genesis 2 introduces a significant shift with the first instance of "not good"—man's solitude (Gen.

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56 * Sujan Pradhan, M.Th. is an Old Testament scholar from Nepal.

2:18). This leads to the creation of woman as a suitable helper עוֹזֵר (*ezer*) and partner בֶּן זוּג *(ben zug*), highlighting their complementary roles. Turner suggests a chiastic structure that integrates Genesis 1's chronological overview with Genesis 2's narrative depth and tension.[57]

Genesis 3 connects to Genesis 2 through thematic wordplay, contrasting the couple's nakedness עָרוֹם (*'arom*), symbolising harmony, with the serpent's craftiness עָרוּם (*'arum*), which introduces conflict. The man's role includes the command to לְהַכְנִיעַ "subdue" and רַזשָׁמ "keep" the earth (Gen. 2:15) and the restriction from eating from the "tree of the knowledge of good and evil," with the Tree of Life presumably available (Gen. 3:3). This juxtaposition sets the stage for the conflict in Genesis 3, highlighting the consequences of disobedience and the broader implications for understanding human roles and divine commands.[58]

ANALYSIS OF DUAL LIBERATION MOTIF IN GENESIS 3

The Genesis creation narrative reflects a dual motif of liberation: God liberates by transforming chaos into order (Gen. 1:1-5) and granting humanity dignity and freedom (Gen. 1-2). The creation of humanity in God's image, the sanctification of the Sabbath, and harmonious relationships in Eden underscore this liberation theme, foreshadowing ultimate redemption through Christ (Rom. 8:1-2; Luke 4:18-19).

However, Sam Dragga offers a contrasting view, interpreting Genesis 2-3 as a tragic narrative marked by the breakdown of trust and harmony due to the serpent's deception. Dragga argues that this leads to alienation, loss of innocence, and the beginning of human suffering and mortality, thereby, framing the expulsion from Eden as a profound loss rather than a redemptive act,[59] presenting a nuanced perspective on the theme of liberation.

1. Destructive Liberation: State of Accountability

In the Genesis creation narrative, God endows humans with freedom and responsibility, reflecting their special status in creation. However, Genesis 3 presents a destructive form of liberation when the serpent deceives Adam and Eve into defying God's command, falsely promising that they would become like God (Gen. 3:4-5). This act leads to immediate consequences: awareness of nakedness, accountability, physical and spiritual death, and separation from God (Gen. 3:7,22-24). This contrasts with true freedom, highlighting that disobedience brings moral and spiritual decline rather than genuine liberation.

2. **Transformative Liberation: State of Innocency**

[57] Laurence A. Turner, *Genesis* (England: Sheffield Academic Press, 2000), 28-29.

[58] Turner, *Genesis*, 26, 28-30.

[59] Sam Dragga, "Genesis 2-3: A Story of Liberation," *Journal for the Study of the Old Testament,* 55 (1992): 3-6.

Transformative liberation refers to the freedom God offers humanity from sin, ultimately fulfilled through the redemptive work of Jesus Christ. In the Garden of Eden, God's justice is demonstrated by expelling Adam and Eve for their disobedience, highlighting the grave consequences of sin (Gen. 3:23-24). Yet, God's promise of a future "Seed" (Gen. 3:15) who would triumph over the forces of destructive liberation, along with his act of clothing Adam and Eve with animal skins (Gen. 3:21), signifies divine mercy. This foreshadows Christ's victorious birth and his atoning sacrifice for humanity.

Christ, the "Lamb of God," bridges the gap between sinful humanity and a holy God, removing sin's deceptive effects and restoring believers' innocence and a right relationship with God (John 1:29; 2 Cor. 5:18-19). This transformative liberation promises eternal life and unbroken communion with God (John 3:16; Rev. 21:3-4).

FREEDOM WITH RESPONSIBILITY

T. Desmond Alexander[60] and J. Richard Middleton[61] highlight the Genesis creation narrative's emphasis on human freedom with responsibility. Unlike other Ancient Near Eastern texts,[62] Genesis presents humans as God's vicegerents, endowed with royal authority to rule over creation and reflect God's image. Ronald Youngblood adds that God's act of creating and forming humanity embodies both physical and spiritual dimensions, establishing a foundational role of stewardship.[63]

Alexander and Middleton emphasise humanity's divine mandate to "till and keep" the Garden (Gen. 2:15) and exercise dominion over creation (Gen. 1:28). This stewardship integrates freedom with duty, where true freedom involves responsible choices, voluntary obedience, and adherence to divine commands. It fosters a relationship with God and ensures the flourishing of creation.

CUNNING SERPENT AND THE DISOBEDIENCE OF ADAM AND EVE

Scholars examine the Genesis 3 narrative, particularly the interaction between the serpent and Eve, as a complex portrayal of deception and disobedience. Laurence A. Turner[64] and Gerhard Von Rad[65] emphasise the serpent's cunning use of half-truths to distort God's

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[60] T. Desmond Alexander, *From Paradise to the Promised Land: An Introduction to the Pentateuch*, 4th ed. (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2022), 15-16.

[61] J. Richard Middleton, *The Liberating Image: The Imago Dei in Genesis 1* (Grand Rapids: Brazos Press, 2005), 110.

[62] For instance, "Enuma Elish" in the creation story of the Babylonian Kingdom.

[63] Ronald Youngblood, *The Book of Genesis: An Introductory Commentary*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids: Baker Book House, 1991), 35-37.

[64] Turner, *Genesis*, 30-31.

[65] Gerhard Von Rad, *Genesis: A Commentary,* Revised edition (Philadelphia: The Westminster Press, 1972), 87-90.

command, exploiting Eve's incomplete understanding to sow doubt about God's goodness. This manipulation leads to a misrepresentation of God's word, eroding trust and prompting disobedience.

Gordon Wenham[66] and Matthew Levering[67] focus on Adam and Eve's desire to be like God, driven by pride and the serpent's promise of autonomy, which leads them away from obedience. Victor P. Hamilton[68] and Ronald Youngblood[69] highlight the consequences of their rebellion, noting the shift from blessing to judgment, conflict, and alienation. Joseph Blenkinsopp underscores the serpent's role in shifting humanity from innocence to shame, symbolising the introduction of sin. Collectively, these scholars reveal the theological implications of the first sin, underscoring the dangers of distorting divine commands and the tragic consequences of rejecting God's authority.[70]

Turner, Von Rad, Wenham, Levering, Hamilton, and Youngblood analyse the serpent in Genesis 3 as a deception that leads humanity to reject divine authority. This act of rebellion has tragic consequences, including exile and loss of access to the Tree of Life, highlighting the dangers of misinterpreting God's commands and seeking autonomy from him.

THE EXPULSION FROM EDEN

Engaging with scholarly perspectives on Adam and Eve's expulsion from Eden reveals a multifaceted understanding of this event as a consequence of their disobedience. G.J. Wenham views Eden as an archetypal sanctuary, where the expulsion signifies a rupture in their relationship with God.[71] Ronald Youngblood[72] and Gerhard von Rad[73] emphasise the narrative's portrayal of alienation from God, highlighting their sin's spiritual and psychological impacts.

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[66] Gordon Wenham, "Genesis 1-15," in *Word Biblical Commentary*, ed. David Allen Hubbard and Glenn W. Baker, Vol.1 (Grand Rapids: Zondervan Academic, 2014): 90.

[67] Matthew Levering, *Engaging The Doctrine of Creation: Cosmos, Creatures, and the Wise and Good Creator* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2017), 227.

[68] Victor P. Hamilton, *The Book of Genesis: Chapters 1-17*, ed. R.K. Harrison and Robert L. Hubbard (Grand Rapids: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1990): 51-52.

[69] Youngblood, *The Book of Genesis,* 53-55.

[70] Joseph Blenkinsopp, *Creation, Un-creation-and Re-creation: A Discursive Commentary on Genesis 1-11* (London: T&T Clark, 2011), 72-73.

[71] Gordon J. Wenham, "Sanctuary Symbolism in the Garden of Eden Story," in *Proceedings of the World Congress of Jewish Studies*, 9 (1985): 19; Gordon J. Wenham, "Sanctuary Symbolism in the Garden of Eden Story," in *I Studied Inscription from Before the Flood: Ancient Near Eastern, Literary, and Linguistic Approaches to Genesis 1-11*, ed. Richard S. Hess and David Toshio Tsumura (Winona Lake: Eisenbrauns, 1994): 399.

[72] Youngblood, *The Book of Genesis, 5*2-53.

[73] Rad, *Genesis: A Commentary,* 91-92.

C. John Collins interprets the "death" in Genesis 3 as a spiritual separation from God,[74] while A. Dillmann frames the expulsion as a universal symbol of humanity's struggle with sin and the need for reconciliation.[75] Turner[76] and Alexander[77] further illustrate how disobedience leads to a loss of status and separation from divine life.[78]Collectively, these scholars provide a comprehensive view of the expulsion, focusing on the relational, spiritual, and theological consequences of disobedience.

GOD'S RESPONSE TO HUMAN SIN

God's response to human sin in Genesis 3 reveals a balance of justice, judgment, and grace. Alexander emphasises the human couple's failure to uphold divine responsibility, resulting in a loss of dominion and separation from God.[79] J.H. Walton highlights the severance from divine communion as the true tragedy, interpreting "death" as spiritual separation.[80] Hamilton[81] counters Richard Dawkins's[82] critique of Christianity by focusing on God's persistent grace and promise of redemption. Gerhard von Rad[83] and Dietrich Bonhoeffer[84] see God's actions, such as providing garments, as acts of preservation and continued relationship. Ronald Youngblood notes the interplay of justice and grace,[85] while Turner highlights the irony of God's provision of animal skins.[86] Together, these views portray God's response as a deliberate act of grace, aiming to restore the broken relationship with humanity.

LIBERATION AS A FORESHADOWING OF REDEMPTION

The liberation in Genesis is a foreshadowing of Christ's redemptive work. The curse on the serpent and the promise of enmity between Eve and the serpent (Gen. 3:15[87]; 2 Cor. 5:21; Heb. 4:15) symbolise Jesus's victory over sin and Satan.[88] When God clothed Adam and Eve

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[74] C. John Collins, "Adam and Eve in the Old Testament," in *Adam, The Fall, and Original Sin: Theological Biblical, and Scientific Perspectives*, ed. Hans Madueme and Michael Reeves (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2014), 26, 30.

[75] A. Dillamann, *Genesis: Critically and Exegetically Expounded*, trans. WM. B. Stevenson, Vol.1 (Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1897), 102, 104.

[76] Turner, *Genesis*, 32.

[77] Alexander, *From Paradise to the Promised Land*, 18.

[78] Youngblood, *The Book of Genesis*, 56.

[79] Alexander, *From Paradise to the Promised Land*, 17-18.

[80] John H. Walton, "Eden, Garden of," in *Dictionary of the Old Testament: Pentateuch*, ed. T.D. Alexander and D. W. Baker (Downers Grove: InterVersity, 2003), 205.

[81] Hamilton, *The Book of Genesis*, 52.

[82] Richard Dawkins, *The God Delusion*, 149.

[83] Rad, *Genesis: A commentary,* 96.

[84] Dietrich Bonhoeffer, *Creation and Fall: A Theological Interpretation of Genesis 1-3* (New York: SCM Press Ltd, 1959), 90.

[85] Youngblood, *The Book of Genesis,* 57.

[86] Turner, *Genesis*, 34.

[87] This verse has been called the Protoevangelium (the "first gospel"), because many believe that the "offspring" or "Seed" refers to Christ and his triumph over Satan. Herbert Wolf, *An Introduction to the Old Testament: Pentateuch* (Bangalore: Omega Book World, 2019), 37.

[88] Wolf, *An Introduction to the Old Testament*, 35.

with garments of skin (Gen. 3:21), it conveyed a profound message of redemption. The Hebrew term for "skin" עָוֹר (*ʻōr*[89]) implies the sacrifice of an innocent animal to cover their shame, pointing ahead to Christ's ultimate sacrifice (John 1:29; 1 John 2:2; 1 Pet. 5:10).[90] Herbert Wolf emphasises that Christ's obedience counters Adam's disobedience, offering eternal life (Col. 3:10).[91] Joseph Blenkinsopp connects the temporary liberation in Genesis to the eternal redemption achieved through Christ, restoring our relationship with God and fulfilling the promise of liberation hinted at in Eden (Rom. 8:22-23).[92]

CONSEQUENCES OF CONTRASTING LIBERATION

The contrasting consequences of liberation in Genesis 3, illustrate the interplay of God's justice and mercy. Youngblood distinguishes divine testing, meant to strengthen faith, from satanic temptation which aims to lead to sin.[93] Adam and Eve's disobedience led to physical and spiritual death and separation from God, but God's act of clothing them with skins (Gen. 3:21) signified atonement and foreshadowed Christ's ultimate sacrifice. This narrative captures both transformative liberation through God's mercy and deceptive liberation, reflecting the ongoing consequences of sin while showing how grace operates within the framework of justice.

IMPLICATIONS OF DESTRUCTIVE AND TRANSFORMATIVE LIBERATION FOR THE NEPALI CHRISTIAN COMMUNITY IN NEPAL AND BEYOND

The implications of destructive and transformative liberation for the Christian community in Nepal are profound. Churches within this community face significant challenges, notably the influence of false teachings that lead to physical and spiritual degradation and societal issues such as caste and class divisions. These problems raise critical questions: Why do community members often accept teachings without scriptural evaluation? What fear drives them to uphold divisive societal norms, hindering their commitment to Christ? Moreover, why does the church struggle to embody the transformative liberation promised by God? These issues will be explored in detail, highlighting the urgent need for reflection and renewal within the Nepali Christian community.

1. **Impact of Destructive Liberation**

[89] F. Brown, S. Driver, and C. Briggs, *The Brown-Driver-Briggs Hebrew and English Lexicon: With an Appendix Containing the Biblical Aramaic* (Peabody: Hendrickson Publishers, 2021), 736.

[90] John H. Walton, *Genesis* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 2009), 115.

[91] Wolf, *An Introduction to the Old Testament*, 36.

[92] Blenkinsopp, *Creation, Un-creation-and Re-creation*, 73.

[93] Youngblood, *The Book of Genesis*, 52-53.

1.1 Deceptive Teachings

In the contemporary Nepali Christian community in Nepal, the challenge of deceptive teachings poses significant threats to authentic faith. Many struggle to discern between partial truths and the full Gospel, reminiscent of the serpent's deception in the Garden of Eden. This confusion is exacerbated by a prioritisation of tradition over Scripture, leading to divisive practices that foster disunity. Liberation from these destructive influences is crucial for the community to have union with Christ and his Word. Therefore, the churches in Nepal must recognize the importance of grounding biblical teachings in Christ.[94] A Christ-centered approach ensures that the message stays true to the core of the Christian faith, deepens our understanding of God, promotes unity among believers, and inspires a transformative life aligned with his will.

1.2 Societal Stratification

Social stratification through caste and class divisions undermines the biblical teaching of unity in diversity within the Nepali Christian community. Unfortunately, these divisions often lead to favouritism and inequality, silencing the voices of the marginalized or unprivileged. As followers of Christ, we must ask ourselves: Do we see people as God sees them? Are we uplifting our community or perpetuating division? Romans 12:2 calls us to transform our minds, not merely our words. 1 Corinthians 12:12-13, 27 and Romans 12:4-5 highlight that genuine unity within the body of Christ involves acknowledging the importance of each member and challenging societal norms that foster division. Church leaders must actively promote a transformative liberation through Christ, fostering genuine inclusivity that reflects God's heart for all people. Let us not just speak about transformation; let us live it.

2. Impact of Transformative Liberation: Christ is a Liberator

Christ as a liberator is essential for addressing both deceptive teachings within the church and societal divisions based on caste and class. His role as a liberator is vividly illustrated in Scripture. In John 8:32, Jesus declares, "Then you will know the truth, and the truth

[94] Christ is the fulfilment of Scripture (Matt. 5:17; Luke 24:44; John 1:45; Acts 3:1; Rom. 10:4) and the centrality of the Gospel (Mark 16:15; John 3:16; Rom. 1:16-17; 1 Cor. 15:1-4; Gal. 1:6-9), the Image of God's Character (John 1:18, 14:9; Col. 1:15; Heb. 1:3; Rom. 11:33-36; Heb. 13:8), transformation and discipleship (Rom. 12:2; Eph. 4:22-24; Col. 3:9-10; Matt. 28:19-20; Luke 9:23; John 13:34-35), unity in diversity (1 Cor. 12:12-14, 18-20, 25-27; Gal. 3:28; Eph. 4:3-6; Col. 3:11), guidance for living (John 14:6; 1 Pet. 2:21; John 8:12; Eph. 5:1-2; Phil. 2:5-8), hope and assurance (1 Tim. 1:1; Col. 1:27; Heb. 6:19-20).

will set you free," underscoring his mission to reveal the truth that breaks the chains of false teachings. Colossians 2:8 warns against being trapped by deceptive philosophies and human traditions that do not align with Christ, emphasizing that his teachings are the bedrock for true liberation from such errors. Additionally, Ephesians 2:14-16 describes how Christ's work on the cross dismantles barriers of hostility and division, creating a unified body of believers regardless of societal stratifications. In the context of caste and class, Galatians 3:28 affirms that in Christ, all societal distinctions are rendered irrelevant, promoting equality and unity among believers. Thus, Christ's liberating work calls for a transformative liberation that fosters a unified and equitable Christian community.

CONCLUSION

The concept of liberation throughout the biblical narrative bridges the gap between humanity's fall and the complete redemption found in Jesus. This theological concept connects the Hebrew Bible's temporary measures to the New Testament's ultimate liberation. In Genesis 3, the dual concept of destructive and transformative liberation is evident: the serpent's deception results in humanity's fall, representing false freedom and the consequences of disobedience. However, within this fall, God's merciful response foreshadows Christ's redemptive work, providing an early indication of the true liberation that Christ alone can offer.

Destructive liberation, exemplified by deceptive teachings and entrenched caste and class divisions, threatens the spiritual and social unity of the Christian community in Nepal. These challenges compromise the biblical call for equality and unity. Conversely, transformative liberation through Christ offers a remedy by exposing false doctrines and dismantling societal barriers. Scripture verses such as, John 8:32, Colossians 2:8, Ephesians 2:14-16, and Galatians 3:28, affirm that true liberation in Christ brings both spiritual clarity and social equality. To fully realize this transformation, the community must embrace inclusivity, align with Christ's vision of unity, and uphold the principles of equity. Celebrating diversity and reforming practices will enable the church to reflect Christ's transformative power, demonstrating that in him, all believers are united. Thus, guided by Christ-centered teachings and strengthened by the Holy Spirit, the Nepali Christian community can live out God's will, overcoming ungodly influences and embodying a unified and equitable unwavering faith.

Glossary

Liberation. This refers to freedom from sin, oppression, and spiritual death, as depicted in both the Old and New Testaments. It involves "positive liberation" aligned with God's will and "negative liberation" that leads to spiritual alienation.

Negative Liberation. A deceptive freedom that leads to spiritual death and separation from God, exemplified by the serpent's temptation of Adam and Eve in Genesis 3.

Positive Liberation. True freedom God provides, leading to harmony, divine relationship, and ultimately fulfilled in Christ's atoning sacrifice.

Ex nihilo. A Latin phrase meaning "out of nothing," referring to God's act of creation without pre-existing materials, as depicted in Genesis 1.

עוֹזֵר (Ezer). A Hebrew word meaning "helper," used in Genesis 2:18 to describe the role of woman in man, emphasising partnership and complementarity.

בֶּן זוּג (Ben zug). A Hebrew term that can be translated as "partner," highlighting the relationship between man and woman as equal and complementary in the Genesis narrative.

Chiastic Structure. A literary structure where ideas are presented in a particular order and then repeated in reverse order, often used to highlight central themes in biblical texts.

עָרוֹם (Nakedness). In Genesis, nakedness symbolises innocence and vulnerability. The contrast between the couple's nakedness and the serpent's craftiness (arum, עָרוּם) introduces the theme of disobedience and shame.

Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil. A central element in the Genesis narrative, symbolising the boundary set by God for human obedience. Eating its fruit leads to the fall and the introduction of sin.

Dominion. The authority given by God to humanity to rule over creation, as described in Genesis 1:28. This concept is central to understanding the roles and responsibilities of humans in the biblical narrative.

Spiritual Death. A state of separation from God, resulting from disobedience, as seen in the consequences of Adam and Eve's sin in Genesis 3.

Cherubim. Angelic beings placed by God to guard the entrance to Eden after Adam and Eve's expulsion, symbolising the loss of access to eternal life and the separation from God.

Sacrificial System. As part of the process for people to be forgiven when they did not live up to the covenant. A key element in the Old Testament is that the shedding of innocent blood serves as atonement for sin. The clothing of Adam and Eve with animal skins in Genesis 3:21 foreshadows this system and the ultimate sacrifice of Christ.

Atonement. The reconciliation of God and humankind through the sacrificial death of Jesus Christ. It is prefigured in the Old Testament and fully realised in the New Testament.

Covenant. A solemn agreement between God and humanity, often involving promises and obligations. The covenant theme runs throughout the Bible, culminating in the New Covenant established by Jesus.

Divine Justice and Mercy. The theological balance of God's righteousness in judging sin and his compassion in providing a way of redemption.

Foreshadowing. A literary device where an element in the narrative hints at future events.

Redemption. The act of being saved from sin, often through the payment of a price. In Christian theology, redemption is achieved through the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

Freedom with Responsibility. The concept that true freedom is exercised within the boundaries of God's will, emphasising voluntary obedience and the flourishing of creation.

Royal Authority. The God-given mandate for humanity to rule over creation as stewards, reflecting God's image and authority on earth.

Imago Dei (Image of God). The belief that humans are created in God's image, which bestows dignity, value, and responsibility upon every person. This concept is central to the creation narrative in Genesis.

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God's Providence in Suffering: The Supreme Comfort

Kapsuanmung[95*]

We are deeply affected and our souls are troubled when we encounter horrific tragedies. Such pain and sorrow raise several inevitable questions concerning God's existence. The three most common queries are: what causes evil, what is the main source of suffering, and why does it happen? As a result, it is crucial to respond to those complex questions that trouble our minds. Therefore, the research title, "God's Providence in Suffering: The Supreme Comfort," investigates those complex questions biblically and philosophically. In fact, the research entails that God sovereignly decreed, ordained, and predestined everything that happens in our lives, including suffering and evil, yet not without sufficient good reasons. Nothing happens in the universe without his permission and intervention. Therefore, the research proposes to embrace God's sovereignty and his providence over afflictions. Learning to embrace and recognize the finger of God in these dreadful situations becomes the supreme comfort.

INTRODUCTION

Everyone goes through suffering in his or her life because suffering is not partial towards anyone and it befalls Christians and non-Christians alike. No one enjoys going through pain. There are some people who are of the belief that suffering is only an illusion (Christian Science sect and some forms of Hinduism), however, that is not true. Suffering is very much real. In many churches today, Christians are reportedly leaning more toward agnosticism, or sometimes even atheism, because of the tragedies that they have encountered in their lives which make them question the goodness of God or even his existence. When people encounter tragedies, they cry out, "Why Lord?" and ask, "Where is God and his providence?"[96] These dreadful experiences pose certain inevitable questions about God—such as, where is God?[97] Is suffering part of his doing or not? Why does a good God allow his people to suffer? Hence, this paper aims to respond to these very important and universally relevant and relatable questions about suffering, biblically and philosophically.

WE HAVE ALL ENCOUNTERED DIFFERENT KINDS OF SUFFERING

As we are currently living in the twenty-first century, the so-called Digital Age, we have seen or gone through a wide range of suffering including social evils—exploitation, corruption, racism, injustice, rape, as well as poverty, oppression by the rich and the powerful,

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95 *Kapsuanmung, M.Th. (Christian Theology) is a scholar from Manipur, India.

96 Bruce Henderson, *Why Does God Let It Happen?* (Pennsylvania, WC: SF Press, 2010), 59.

97 John M. Frame, *The Doctrine of God* (Phillipsburg, New Jersey: P&R, 2002), 196.

unemployment etc.[98] Similarly, the world has also been witnessing different kinds of war including ethnic conflict, civil war, revolutionary war, counter-insurgency, terrorism, etc. In this context, the state of Manipur has also been facing unprecedented ethnic violence since May 3, 2023 in which hundreds of precious lives have been lost and countless properties including more than 350 churches destroyed in this ongoing clash. Additionally, we have also lost our dear ones and properties in natural disasters—such as floods, droughts, earthquakes, landslides, lightning strikes, glaciers, etc.

Furthermore, almost everyone faces some kind of sickness, or disease, or plague, or epidemic, or uncurable disease—cancer and AIDS—and some even succumb to the condition sometimes. In the recent past, the entire world was subject to COVID-19 in which millions lost their lives. Many people have lost their lives in accidents. In such situations, it feels natural for one to question, "Where was God in this?"[99] Many faithful Christian believers in India have been persecuted at the hands of fanatic Hindu zealots. They were chased out of their own houses, mistreated and discriminated against, and beaten even to death, and church properties were vandalized. Many other untold atrocities have also been committed. All these are tragic indeed, yet it is the reality that we live in. Unable to grasp the sovereignty of God in these difficult circumstances, many people consider these sufferings unrelated to any divine plan, however, we cannot deny that they are in fact, "acts of God."[100]

CAUSES OF SUFFERING

In order to understand why a good and omnipotent God would allow suffering in this world, we need to understand God's providence in view of the existence of evil. Philosophers call this theological construct theodicy. Suffering and evil are divided into two inextricably related categories—natural and moral. *Natural evil* is anything that brings suffering and difficulty into the lives of creatures—such as floods, earthquakes, sickness, pestilence, viruses, death, and so on. *Moral evil* is something that involves human action or volition—such as sexual violence, war, injustice, discrimination, and all forms of cruelty to both humans and animals.[101] The primary cause of our suffering and evil has two premises:

1. The Biblical Premise:

[98] D.A. Carson, *How Long, O Lord? Reflection on Suffering and Evil* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2006), 63.

[99] David Pawson, *Why Does God Allow Natural Disaster* (Kennington, Ashford: Anchor Recordings Ltd, 2017), 6.

[100] Henderson, *Why Does God Let It Happen?*, 65.

[101] Derek W.H. Thomas, "A Pastoral Theology of Suffering," *Reformed Faith & Practice: The Journal of Reformed Theological Seminary* https://journal.rts.edu/article/a-pastoral-theology-of-suffering/#post-1931-footnote-4.

The biblical evidence shows that suffering—even as evil—came into the world as a consequence of sin. However, the entrance of evil and suffering came only as a part of God's eternal decree. He ordains and allows suffering and evil. The eighth-century BC prophet, Isaiah, communicated that God created "light and darkness" as well as "well-being and calamity" (Is. 45:7; Micah 1:12). In other words, he created and ordained the hostility and wicked hearts of human beings (Is. 10:5-12). The Hebrew word for "evil" or "calamity" is רָע [The noun רָעָה (*rā'á*) is translated as both natural sense—calamity (Gen. 19:19; Deut. 30:15; Is. 3:11), and moral sense—evil and wickedness (Gen. 50:20; Ps. 15:3)][102]. This idea is further communicated by the use of participle verbsיוֹצֵר (forming), וּבוֹרֵא (and creating), עֹשֶׂה (making) which indicate that God is the Creator; he determines everything in the universe including all human actions and natural events (Is. 45: 1-4).[103] Proverbs 16:4 likewise affirms that God created everything including the "wicked for the day of evil." Furthermore, the prophet, Amos declares that sometimes calamity (3:2) occurs under the will of God (Amos 3:6b). Therefore, everything exists only when the Lord commands them (Lam. 3:37-39) for he decrees and creates them providentially without himself being evil or sinful (Eccl. 7:14; Lam. 1:18).

Additionally, Jesus Christ's suffering and death on the cross were not by chance or accident, but divinely decreed, ordained, and predestined before the foundation of the world including every detail of lawless men, time, and place (Acts 2:23, 4:27-28). However, God withholds the details of how he simultaneously decrees and allows good and evil. It is incomprehensible and a mystery.

2. The Philosophical Premise:

The so-called *philosophical compatibilism* proposition entails that God sovereignly allows evil and suffering with sufficient providence. He eternally decrees, ordains, and authors suffering and evil. In other words, God permits, allows, determines, and arranges evil without being the doer of evil, or the sinner, or the actor of sin, or the agent. Accordingly, Jonathan Edwards equivocally argues, "If, by the author of sin, be meant the sinner, the agent, or the actor of sin, or the doer of a wicked thing… blasphemy to suppose God to be the author of sin…But if, by the author of sin, is meant the permitter, or not a hinderer of sin… I do not deny that God is the author of sin."[104]

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[102] William D. Mounce, *Mounce's Complete Expository Dictionary of Old & New Testament Words* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2006), 222.

[103] John Piper, *Providence* (Wheaton, Illinois: Crossway, 2020), 353-4.

[104] Jonathan Edwards, *Freedom of the Will* (London: Hamilton, Adams & Co., 1860), 262.

An open theist John Sanders claims that natural disaster is caused by natural elements "a degree of autonomy."[105] Libertarians Robert Picirilli and Kathrin Rogers also argue that if God is the author and determines it, he must be responsible and that makes him evil.[106] This makes it seem that if God is the efficient cause of evil, he does evil things. However, they left the terms—author, cause, and determine—unanalyzed and ambiguous without explicitly defining them, which made them sound foggy.[107] In contrast, James Anderson argues that God never commits evil acts although he foreordains the evil acts of creatures. Creatures commit evil acts by exercising their freewill, which is not the same thing as God committing them.[108] A French philosopher, Bignon, further says, "…evils have morally sufficient reasons for why their occurrence would be overall preferable…that God is even praiseworthy for bringing about these preferable states of affairs that include evil."[109] Thus, we can logically say that God authors sin without being sinful and morally responsible. However, his righteous nature is not incoherent with his being the permitter of evil (Deut. 32:4; Hab. 1:13).

WHY DID GOD ORDAIN SUFFERING?

The biblical and philosophical premises testify that—no tragedy happens without purpose and no suffering occurs without a reason[110]—God has sufficiently good reason for ordaining and determining evil and suffering. Three significant reasons are, as follows:

1. **To display the greatness of God's glory**: The primary purpose of God's decree and ordination of evil and suffering is to display the greatness of his glory. God decreed everything from eternity according to his eternal decree and plan (1 Pet. 1:6-7, 4:16; Eph. 1:6) to manifest his glory. The suffering of Jesus Christ at Calvary is the supreme, highest, clearest manifestation of the glory of God's grace.[111]
2. **For the ultimate good of his people**: Romans 8:28 says, "…all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose." The bad things that happen in our lives are for our good. This is the purpose of God

[105] John Sanders, *The God Who Risks* (Downers Grove, Illinois: IVP Academic, 2007), 108.

[106] Robert E. Picirilli, *Grace, Faith, Free Will* (Nashville, Tennessee: Randall House Pub., 2002), 47; Kathrin A. *Rogers, "*Does God Cause Sin? Anselm of Canterbury Versus Jonathan Edwards on Human Freedom and Divine Sovereignty*," Faith and Philosophy: Journal of the Society of Christian Philosophers 20, 3 (2003),* 372.

[107] Frame, *The Doctrine of God*, 174.

[108] James N. Anderson, "Calvinism and the First Sin" in *Calvinism and the Problem of Evil*, ed. David E. Alexander and Daniel M. Johnson (Eugene, Oregon: Pickwick Pub., 2016), 227.

[109] Guillaume Bignon, *Excusing Sinners and Blaming God* (Eugene, Oregon: Pickwick Pub., 2018), 233.

[110] David Powlison, *God's Grace in Your Suffering* (Wheaton, Illinois: Crossway, 2018), 44.

[111] John Piper, "The Suffering of Christ and the Sovereignty of God" in *Suffering and the Sovereignty of God,* ed. John Piper and Justin Taylor (Wheaton, Illinois: Crossway, 2006), 82.

ordaining suffering in our lives. Joseph's suffering exhibits that his brothers' intentions were wicked, nevertheless, God meant it for good—to save many people (Gen. 50:20).

3. **A discipline for believers**: When afflictions fall upon the wicked or nonbelievers, it is usually a sign of God's wrath and judgment on them so that they may come to know the true God. However, for believers, it is a sign of God disciplining them, and keeping them from wrongdoing. Hebrews 12:6 says, "For the Lord disciplines the one he loves, and chastises every son whom he receives." Therefore, "No one suffers without cause."[112] Perhaps, "We may defy and reject God's plan, but we cannot escape it."[113]

WHY DO CHRISTIANS SUFFER?

Once, Charles Spurgeon stated, "He who demands a reason from God is not in a fit state to receive one."[114] He was probably referring to an arrogant attitude towards God. However, asking why we suffer in our deepest pain and sorrow is not sinful or bad. There are several reasons why God permits us to go through severe afflictions sometimes:

1. To foster communion with Christ

Some of us may have lost our dear ones—a family member or a close friend—due to sickness, accident, drug abuse, murder, natural disaster, pandemic, civil war, persecution leading to martyrdom for Christ, etc. The intense pain and sorrow that follow these tragedies, penetrate our hearts and trouble our souls. However, grief and miseries usually bring us to our knees from where we look upon the suffering of Christ and that results in a close fellowship with him. Because we share in Christ's suffering, as 1 Peter 4:13 says, "But rejoice insofar as you share Christ's suffering, that you may also rejoice and be glad when his glory is revealed." In such a manner, we can find peace and comfort when we are united with Christ, the Greatest Sufferer.

2. Suffering: A test of faith

Our hardships are also meant to be a test of faith. God wants to test the genuineness of our faith by sometimes putting us through severe pain. The book of James states that trials are "the testing of your faith" (James 1:2). In all of his pains and afflictions, Job sees the hand of God and understands his providence—for the good of his soul (Job 1-2). When his wife told him to curse God and die (Job 2:9), Job said to her, "Shall we receive good from God, and

[112] Philip Yancey, *Where is God When it Hurts?* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1977), 88.
[113] J. I. Packer, *God's Plans for You* (Wheaton, Illinois: Crossway, 2001), 24.
[114] Charles Spurgeon, Sermon 1778, "A Heavenly Pattern for Our Earthly Life".

shall we not receive evil?" (2:10). Job's suffering causes him to long for God and it strengthens his faith. Furthermore, Abraham and Sarah struggled with infertility. However, Abraham's faith was put to the test after they had Isaac, when God asked him to sacrifice his only son. Thus, suffering is a test of faith which leads to strengthening of our faith.

3. A tool for sanctification

Suffering sanctifies and purifies believers from the love of earthly pleasure. God graciously cleanses us by putting us through suffering. As Isaiah 48:10 says, "Behold, I have refined you, but not as silver; I have tried you in the furnace of affliction." Suffering is always designed for our benefit since it makes us introspect on why we suffer. It brings us to perceive the depth of our sins thereby, leading us to repentance. Thus, it mortifies our sins and cleanses our hearts. The Prince of Preachers, Spurgeon, who had experienced deep depression once said, "When the gold knows why and wherefore it is in the fire…[it] will thank the Refiner for putting it into the crucible, and will find a sweet satisfaction even in the flames."[115] Therefore, suffering cleanses our hearts and produces sincere faith, godliness, and spiritual fruit.[116]

4. Suffering is integral to discipleship

The first principle of discipleship is complete submission under Christ's feet, that is, to adhere to the perfect model set by him, as he sets a standard for how his disciples ought to handle suffering. Bonhoeffer said that discipleship, "means allegiance to the suffering Christ."[117] If we want to follow our Master, we must deny ourselves, take up our cross (Matt. 16:24), and pay the price. Timothy Keller rightly pointed out, "Suffering is at the very heart of the Christian faith. It is not only the way Christ became like and redeemed us, but it is one of the main ways we also become like him and experience his redemption."[118] Indeed, suffering is an integral component of Christian life.

6. To cultivate prayer and meditation life

Prayer is one of the most effective means to discern the invisible hand of God's providence. When we cry and pour out our sorrow, pain, and agony humbly to the Lord in prayer, he grants us inner peace and comfort (Ps. 18:6). The Scripture directs us to pray fervently in times of hardships: "Is any among you suffering? Let him pray." (James 5:13). In this regard,

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[115] C.H. Spurgeon, *The Sword and Trowel* (London: Passmore & Alabaster), 36.

[116] Brian H. Cosby, *Suffering and Sovereignty: John Flavel and the Puritans on Afflictive Providence* (Grand Rapids, MI: Reformation Heritage Books, 2012), 56.

[117] Dietrich Bonhoeffer, *The Cost of Discipleship* (New York: Macmillan Pub. Co., Inc., 1963), 101.

[118] Timothy Keller, *Walking with God Through Pain and Suffering* (New York: Penguin Group, 2013), 236-237.

R.C. Sproul once said, "Prayer is a vital vehicle, or tool… By prayer, our thoughts are lifted toward him and our hearts are bent to his perfect will."[119]

Consistent meditation is the foundation for the consolation and peace of the afflicted Christian. When we meditate on the Word of God, he speaks to us through his living Word, and he reveals his will (Ps. 119:15). Meditation helps us to understand our pain and reduces spiritual and emotional pain. It relieves us of our pain and inflames in our hearts, affection for the Lord. Meditation consoles the afflicted souls.[120] Thus, undergoing pain and sorrow fosters a desire for a life of prayer and meditation in us, because we quest after the reason for our suffering.

7. The heavenly glory: The spiritual vaccine

Suffering causes us to help our eyes focused on what is invisible and eternal—heavenly hope.[121] As Apostle Paul longed for future glory as he compared it to his present suffering (Rom. 8:18), we likewise recognize that our present sufferings are momentary which causes us to long for heavenly glory. This is truly our spiritual vaccine. Paul further says, "…momentary affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory beyond all comparison…" (2 Cor. 4:17-18). When we understand that suffering is transient and is designed to prepare us for our heavenly home, we find in us a new and deep longing for an eternal abode.[122] This further produces relief from our pains and comforts us with peace, endurance, joy, and hope, for "he [God] will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away" (Rev. 21:4).

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, our pains and hardships are not by chance and no tragedy happens without purpose because God has ordained all our days and written in his book before we were born (Ps. 139:16). Thus, he already determined our purpose and planned out everything we needed to fulfill his plan. In his book, *Chosen by God*, R.C. Sproul says, "If there is one single molecule in this universe running around loose, totally free of God's sovereignty then we have no guarantee that a single promise of God will ever be fulfilled."[123] When we suffer

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[119] R.C. Sproul, *The Invisible Hand: Do All Things Really Work for Good?* (Dallas: Word Pub., 1997), 201.

[120] David W. Saxton, *God's Battle Plan for the Mind: The Puritan Practice of Biblical Meditation* (Grand Rapids, MI: Reformation Heritage Books, 2015), 99.

[121] John Flavel, *Touchstone of Sincerity* in *The Work of Rev. Mr. John Flavel*, vol. 5 (London: W. Baynes and Son, 1820), 576.

[122] Paul David Tripp, *Suffering: Gospel Hope When Life Doesn't Make Sense* (Wheaton, Illinois: Crossway, 2018), 136.

[123] R. C. Sproul, *Chosen by God* (Wheaton, Illinois: Tyndale House Pub., 1986), 26-27.

unjustly, whether physically or emotionally or spiritually, we are sharing in Jesus's tremendous unjust suffering and punishment,[124]—who endured severe emotional, physical, and spiritual suffering on the cross (Is. 53:3; Luke 18:32; Matt. 26:38, 27:46). It is not wrong or sinful for us to ask why we suffer for being followers of Christ. However, we can also ask another question: Why not suffer, if Jesus, the divine-human person and "God himself in the god-forsakenness of Christ"[125] underwent severe afflictions? Therefore, all these sufferings were ordained and determined by God and nothing happens without his permission and intervention. If God decreed, ordained, and determined everything that happens in our lives, undoubtedly, they must all have sufficiently good reasons. As a result, when we suffer, we should be joyful and grateful because we have the opportunity to share in Christ's suffering. Since God's presence is felt the most in the depths of our pain and we recognize that all our afflictions are pre-determined and have a good purpose, this knowledge ultimately gives us comfort and peace in our hearts.

[124] John MacArthur, *The Power of Suffering: Strengthening Your faith in the Refiner's Fire* (Wheaton, Illinois: Victor Books, 1995), 34.

[125] Jurgen Moltmann, *The Crucified God* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1993), 234.